activities. Clandestine smuggling of arms and ammunition and fortification of the Akal Takht by Maj. Gen. Shahbeg Singh had started by March 1984, and were being conveniently overlooked by the security apparatus concerned.

The next general elections were due by January 1985, and the Congress needed adequate time to consolidate the gains arising out of the planned ‘final solution’. Postponing it further would now be counterproductive. It was, therefore, time for Indira Gandhi to act decisively and live up to her by now somewhat dented image of a strong leader capable of taking the strongest possible action.

The planning stage

The justification for such an action was provided by Harchand Singh Longowal on 23 May 1984, when he announced that starting 3 June, no food grains would be allowed to move out of Punjab, and that Sikhs would not pay taxes and dues. With the Punjab police and paramilitary forces incapable of clearing the by-now heavily armed Akal Takht complex, army’s involvement became inevitable. Consequently, the PM called Chief of the Army Staff General A.S. Vaidya on 25 May to discuss the situation. She told him to keep the army ready to help the civilian authorities in Punjab, to which General Vaidya replied that anticipating such an eventuality, he had already ordered troop movement in Punjab.

The initial plan, as explained by General Vaidya, was confined to siege-and-flushing-out operations in the identified gurudwaras, including the Golden Temple, by using adequate force to prevent movement of men, food stocks and weapons into these gurudwaras and force the extremists to surrender. Vaidya assured her that there would be ‘maximum show of force and minimum use of that’. He also assured her that during the operation no damage would be caused to the targeted gurudwara buildings, especially to the Golden Temple complex. [2]

According to Alexander, Indira Gandhi clearly defined the main objectives of the army operation by saying that ‘the top priorities of the army would be to effectively curb terrorism and violence, provide security to the people and restore normalcy in Punjab. The